

SKY WANDERERS

Between Mars and Jupiter there is a belt of rocks in orbit called the asteroid belt. The chunks of rock are called asteroids. Sometimes these pieces crash into each other and pieces fall down toward Earth.

Also in orbit around the sun are lumps of rock and ice, called comets. When comets get near the sun they shine like 'hairy stars' which is what people used to call them long ago. The most famous comet is Halley's Comet, named after the man who first studied it.

Earth comets

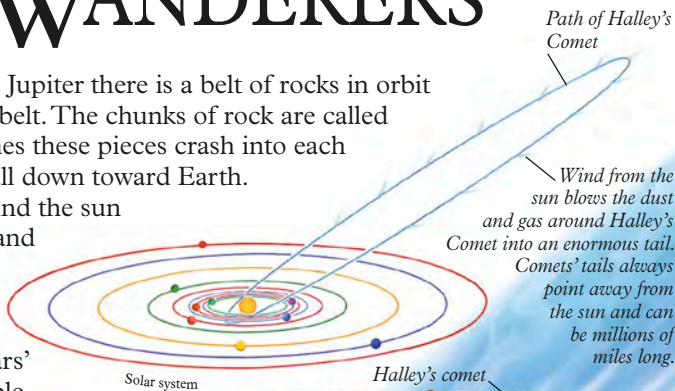
Because they are made of rock and ice, comets are often called "dirty snowballs." Make your own comet next time it snows!



The comet's center is made of ice. As it gets near the sun some of the ice melts.

A belt you cannot wear

There are thousands of asteroids in the asteroid belt. Some are tiny specks of dust, and others are nearly 620 miles (1,000 kilometers) across.

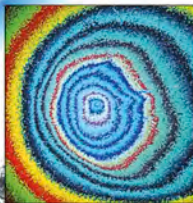


Wind from the sun blows the dust and gas around Halley's Comet into an enormous tail. Comets' tails always point away from the sun and can be millions of miles long.



Regular visitor

We see Halley's Comet from Earth once every 76 years because it takes that long to orbit the sun. It was shown on a picture, called the Bayeux Tapestry, over 900 years ago!



Comet head

This is a photograph of the head of Halley's Comet. Computer colors show the bright center and the layers round it.